



CAPE TOWN SOUTH AFRICA

Bobotie Beneath Table Mountain

Situated near Africa's southern tip, cosmopolitan Cape Town is a city of singular natural beauty. Rising from a gorgeous natural harbor to the footslopes of iconic Table Mountain, it is also the home of *bobotie*, the definitive dish of the Cape Malay community, whose fusion of Indonesian, Dutch, and indigenous elements has created a unique cuisine emblematic of the city itself.



Boasting world-class restaurants that represent every conceivable global cuisine, Cape Town is Africa's culinary answer to London or New York – but with the added advantages of a warm climate, a tourist-friendly exchange rate, and one of the world's top winelands on the doorstep. It's ironic, then, that you could spend quite some time in Cape Town without realizing that it boasts its own distinctive cuisine; but possible, because Cape Malay cuisine, like the community, stands slightly outside the South African mainstream.

The Cape Malay are an anomaly. In a land whose history is dominated by the clash between indigenous Africans and European settlers, this tightly knit community is descended from Indonesian slaves and religious dissidents brought here by the earliest Dutch settlers. The community retains a strong Islamic identity, despite South Africa being predominantly Christian, yet its mother tongue is the Dutch derivative called Afrikaans, while the famously sentimental songs performed by its choirs are called *Nederlandsliede* (Dutch Songs).

Unsurprisingly, Cape Malay cuisine is a curious mixture. The curries are sweeter and milder than their Indonesian forerunners due to the use of fruit preserves. *Sosaties* – kebabs soaked in a sweet, spicy marinade – are a linguistic fusion of the Dutch *sous* (sauce) and Indonesian satay (skewered meat). And the inclusion of Cape pondweed in a lamb dish called *waterblommetjebredie* (water-flower stew) is borrowed from the indigenous Khoikhoi. The national dish of South Africa, *bobotie*, was probably introduced to the Cape by early Dutch settlers before being re-adopted by their Indonesian slaves. Rather like a spicy moussaka, it comprises a fruity, curried ground meat base, topped with an egg sauce that forms a crust when baked.

Cape Malay culture still thrives in the Bo-Kaap (Upper Cape), a residential district of brightly painted houses that offers superb views across the city bowl to the unmistakable flat top of Table Mountain – accessed from downtown by a thrilling revolving cable car. Farther afield, Cape Town offers limitless opportunities for memorable expeditions, including whale-watching in False Bay, a hike to the clifftop Cape Point Lighthouse, or a boat trip to Robben Island.



Above Cape Town sits at the foot of the spectacular Table Mountain, which dominates the city skyline; the summit can be reached in minutes by cable car

Cape Wines

Viniculture in the Cape dates back to 1659, when the colony's founder Jan van Riebeeck produced a small amount of doubtless rather rough wine. The subsequent arrival of French Huguenots prompted the fledgling industry to spread inland to **Stellenbosch**, **Franschhoek**, and **Paarl**, the site of historic vineyards such as Blaauwklippen, Boschendal, and Vergelegen. Today, South Africa is the world's seventh-largest wine producer, with about a dozen different grape varieties. **Cabernet Sauvignon**, the most widely planted red, produces heavy wines that complement red meats. **Pinotage**, a uniquely South African cultivar, makes a fruity, purple wine that often represents the best value among the reds. Of the whites, **Sauvignon Blanc** provides a crisp, zesty complement to Cape Malay dishes and seafood.

Three Days in and around Cape Town

Cape Town and its immediate environs could easily keep you busy for two weeks. It boasts iconic mountains, rustic wine estates, colorful botanical gardens, modern shopping malls, windswept oceanic cliffs, and superb swimming beaches, all set against the craggy spine of Table Mountain National Park (TMNP).

DAY ONE Head to the summit of **Table Mountain**, which is most easily reached by cable car. It has interesting wildlife and offers breathtaking views in all directions. After lunching at **Noon Gun**, head to the **Company's Gardens**, founded by van Riebeeck and encircled by historic landmarks such as the **Old Slave Lodge**, **National Museum**, **St. George's Cathedral**, and **House of Parliament**.

DAY TWO Take off for the **Western Cape Peninsula** and the **Constantia Winelands**, taking in the spectacular Cape of Good Hope sector of **TMNP** and the penguin colony at **Boulders**. Lunch at Groot Constantia's **Jonkershuis Restaurant**, then enjoy an afternoon stroll around **Kirstenbosch Botanical Garden**.

DAY THREE Visit sedate old **Stellenbosch**, famed for its wealth of Cape Dutch architecture, then go wine-tasting in the surrounding **Cape Winelands**.

Essentials

GETTING THERE

Most international flights land at **Johannesburg**, two hours by air from Cape Town; **trains** and **buses** connect the cities. There are also direct flights from Europe to **Cape Town International Airport**, 30 minutes from downtown.

WHERE TO STAY

For a cozy bargain, the **Lord Nelson Inn** (inexpensive) in historic Simonstown is hard to beat. www.lordnelsoninn.co.za

Cape Town Hollow (moderate) is a conveniently central hotel situated opposite the Company's Gardens. www.capetownhollow.co.za

The Cape Grace (expensive) is the epitome of contemporary five-star chic. www.capegrace.com

TOURIST INFORMATION

www.tourismcapetown.co.za